Buniyaad

Ramesh Sippy, the director of India's greatest box-office hit *Sholay*; Manohar Shyam Joshi, the writer of *Hum Log* (1984), India's first telenovela; and I as producer got together to make *Buniyaad* (1986–87)—the saga of a Punjabi family's rise and fall in the backdrop of Partition and an underlay of idealism in the lives of the main protagonists. A lot of attention to detail came courtesy Prof. Pushpesh Pant, a cultural anthropologist, and eminent Hindi novelist Krishna Sobti. With realistic sets designed by veteran art director Sudhendhu Roy and photographed by the acclaimed cinematographer K.K. Mahajan, *Buniyaad* still remains one of the best fiction shows on Indian TV. Carefully nuanced, the Joshi–Sippy duo was helped by one of the best ensembles of fine actors: Alok Nath, Anita Kanwar, Kanwaljit Singh, Rajesh Puri, Mazhar Khan, Dilip Tahil, Soni Razdan, Kiran Juneja, Asha Sachdev, Sudhir Pandey, Vijayendra Ghatge, Neena Gupta and Pallavi Joshi.



Chitrahaar/ Rangoli

As unique as the Indian tradition of songs in films, *Chitrahaar* (1982–) and *Rangoli* (1988–) were not inspired by any foreign format but evolved in the musty corridors of Doordarshan. Come Wednesday evenings and early Sunday mornings, people across India would line up before the nearest TV set to watch these medleys of favourite film songs. Later, as these shows were thrown open for bidding, I and some other producers would pay upwards of Rs 1 crore per week to DD for their telecast/production rights. We reimagined it as a simple, thematically woven garland of songs with star anchors, and logged the highest ratings for years.



Mirza Ghalib

When Gulzar, Jagjit Singh and Naseeruddin Shah combine to recreate the life of one of India's greatest poets, you are sure to get a masterpiece, low budget notwithstanding. Telecast on Doordarshan in 1988, *Mirza Ghalib* is the rare serial on a literary figure, with exquisite music, acting and ambience. Gulzar brings a detached empathy to Ghalib's character—you catch glimpses of humour, sarcasm, romance and tragedy. The dialogues faithfully echoing the unique lingo of old Delhi's *galiyaan* (lanes and alleys) is an audio-visual treat. Jagjit Singh composes and sings some of Ghalib's best poems as an added bonus. Besides Naseer's fantastic performance, Parikshit Sahni, Tanvi Azmi, Neena Gupta, Shafi Inamdar and Sudhir Dalvi put in top-class cameos as well.





Bharat Ek Khoj

This magnum opus by Shyam Benegal, based on Nehru's The Discovery of India, was for a whole generation their first lesson in Indian history, from the Indus Valley to Independence. Ace writers (Shyam himself, Shama Zaidi, Sunil Shanbag, Satyadev Dubey and Vasant Dev); sterling actors like Naseeruddin Shah, Om Puri, Irrfan Khan; V.K. Murthy's camera lingering studiously on pared-down sets and believable costumery, in sync with Vanraj Bhatia's thoughtful music, this 53-episode series (aired from Nov. 1988 to Nov. 1989) broke the Raja Ravi Varma-style calendar art imagery for historical characters. And the narrative style–Roshan Seth's Nehru with a counterview by Om Puri–was fascinating.